animals, a horse and a bull, engraved on it side by side.[46] At the same time, some of these engravings appear to be Indian in inspiration. Above the scarab with the lion's back is engraved a nandipada. This symbol is unlikely to be of Greek or Persian inspiration. Similarly, the bull, notwithstanding its wings, is typically Indian, not Persian. The scaraboid seals are in fact curiously reminiscent of seals in the Indus civilization of the third millennium BCE, some of which were shaped in ways similar to those in the Persian Gulf and Mesopotamia, even as the designs and script characters on them were typically Indian. Square and rectangular Indus seals in Mohenjodaro were, we know, embossed with Mesopotamian designs. The interconnections of trade between Taxila and the West are what the engravings on the scaraboid seals evoke, the hot money being on their use by merchants for transactions relating to West Asia and beyond.

Since the seals were not found clustered in one part of Taxila, it seems unlikely that there was a specific merchant's quarter in the city. The same seems true for people practising other crafts. Craftspeople are occasionally visible here and there: a crucible with a pointed bottom lined thickly with burnt sandy clay, a precious metal polisher, and a chalcedony burnisher of the type used for polishing small gold and silver articles—all these evoke the presence of metal craftspeople.[47] They are not limited to any particular sector of the city.

How much of Taxila's character and commerce, its citizens and the caretakers of the city, was visible to Ashoka is unknown. But this was a city that impressed him because many years later, as the Mauryan monarch, he is said to have built a magnificent structure in Taxila. This was outside the city, on the rocky spurs and knolls that lay to the east of the Bhir, where he created a new kind of religious establishment. The worship in this new structure was qualitatively different from that carried out via rituals connected with the deities of the city and its temple. Known as the Dharmarajika, this was a Buddhist stupa whose Mauryan fabric has